Site brief: Golf Rd, Niles vs 111th St, Mount Greenwood

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Bottom line

Both sites rank in the top four of 66 distinct local peaks across Cook County, but I would visit Golf Rd first and I lean against 111th St. Site 1 (Golf Rd & Fernwood Dr, Niles) scores 76.0 and stays in the top 15 in 98% of 300 random re-weightings. Site 4 (the 111th St corridor in Mount Greenwood, hexagon at 107th St & W 109th St) scores 74.8 and holds up in 82%, but a field look turns up an existing chain and a fast-food drive-through, shallow lots, and cemetery and golf-course land inside the hexagon.

This is a hypothetical portfolio study of a drive-through coffee shop, not a real site recommendation.

Side by side

The two sites are close on score and income. Site 4 has more residents nearby and half the competition in a 5-minute drive. Site 1 sits on busier road.

Measure	Site 1: Golf Rd, Niles	Site 4: 111th St, Mount Greenwood
Score (0 to 100)	76.0	74.8
In the top 15 in 300 re-weightings	98%	82%
Residents within 1.5 km	17,815	22,017
Household income	$124k	$123k
Competitors counted within 1.5 km	1	1
Busiest nearby arterial (vehicles per day)	37,900	16,600
Residents within a 5-minute drive	33,887	31,471
Competitors in the 5-minute area	13	6.5

Measure	Site 1: Golf Rd, Niles	Site 4: 111th St, Mount Greenwood
Residents within a 10-minute drive	131,482	145,777
Competitors in the 10-minute area	40	41.5

Across all 7,165 candidate cells the median is 12,084 residents within 1.5 km and a household income of $99k. Competitor counts are lower bounds. A cafe counts 0.5, so counts can end in .5.

Site 1: Golf Rd & Fernwood Dr, Niles

Site 1 wins on road traffic and on few competitors for the number of residents. Ranked against all 11,584 hexagons, it sits at the 95th percentile for residents per competitor and for the busiest arterial (37,900 vehicles a day), the 86th for gas stations nearby, and the 79th for few competing shops. It is weaker on nearby offices (37th) and fast food (48th). Only 5% of households have no vehicle, and 69% of workers drive alone.

On the ground, the hexagon sits on a residential block, but the Golf Rd corridor around it is a major retail node. The best corner is an operating bank with access from both directions. The score finds the area; the parcel is a separate question.

Site 4: 111th St, Mount Greenwood

Site 4 looks better than Site 1 on people and weaker on road. It has 22,017 residents within 1.5 km, the 98th percentile for residents per competitor, the 91st for driving alone to work, and a household income of $123k. Its busiest arterial carries 16,600 vehicles a day, the 50th percentile.

The field look is where I lean against it. The surrounding blocks score well, but 111th St already has a chain and a fast-food drive-through, the lots are shallow, and part of the hexagon is cemetery and golf course. The model counts one coffee competitor within 1.5 km and treats fast-food drive-throughs as a draw, a nearby-business factor, not as competition for coffee. That is a gap between what the score sees and what a driver sees.

How much to trust the ranking

The ranking depends on the weights, and Site 1 is more robust than Site 4. In 300 random re-weightings, where each factor weight is multiplied by a random number between 0.5 and 1.5, Site 1 made the top 15 in 98% of runs and Site 4 in 82%. Only six of the 15 top sites reach 90% or more.

What-if scenarios show what drives the result:

- **No competition terms, or demand only:** none of the 15 sites stays in the top 15. Competition does much of the work.
- **Competition counted double:** 10 of the 15 stay. In a re-run, Site 1 moves to rank 7 and Site 4 to rank 10.
- **No road traffic terms:** the order flips. Site 4 rises to rank 1 and Site 1 falls to rank 7, because Site 1 leans on its busy arterial.

The 1.5 km radius is a rough stand-in for a drive. A 10-minute drive area holds about 8.5 times the residents of the radius on average, and the two rank sites with a correlation of 0.80. At a 5-minute drive Site 4 has half the competition of Site 1 (6.5 against 13), but at 10 minutes they are level (41.5 against 40).

Next steps and limits

The next step is a walk of both corridors, not more modeling. Count coffee competitors on foot, because the data gives a lower bound. Then check parcels, lot depth, access and turning movements, zoning, and rent, none of which are in the data.

Limits to keep in mind:

- **Competition is a lower bound.** Overture is incomplete, and the chain list covers four chains and no independent shops.
- **A traffic count is not an audience.** Counts come from Illinois only.
- **Drive-time areas use free-flow speeds**, so rush-hour areas are smaller.
- **No site-level reality.** Parcels, zoning, access, rent and permitting are not in the data.

Sources: Overture Maps places; U.S. Census Bureau ACS 5-year via the Census Data API (this product is not endorsed or certified by the Census Bureau); IDOT traffic counts; the chains' public store locators (June 2026); OpenStreetMap through openrouteservice by HeiGIT (CC BY-SA 4.0). Scores and rankings are my own calculations. See the live map, the interactive app and the repository.